

Deliverable 1: Needfinding

Team Name: Team 4

Project Goal:

We're building a mobile-first app to help students and young adults find local volunteering opportunities easily and stay motivated.

Individual Interviews

Jonathan Gonzalez

Name: Daniel Regio

Volunteers at: Food Bank

Overview of what Dan told me:

Dan is very passionate about volunteering; he loves how rewarding the role is. When he takes the time to volunteer, he prefers spending his time at the local Food Bank. Here he retrieves donated items from pallets or boxes and sorts them into bags to later distribute. While he is sorting he loves to talk with other similarly passionate people and has made good friends.

What I asked:

What got you interested in volunteering?

Dan: "I basically had lots of free time and instead of playing video games or watching movies, I decided to look up some places to volunteer."

What have you found to be the most challenging about getting started?

Dan: "Honestly, it's sorting through all the options out there. You kind of figure everyone needs help but you start to wonder where could I be most helpful - it becomes a rather introspective situation and you start thinking about what you are actually good at. After all, you want to do the best to help those around you."

Can you name any pain points you have about the work you currently do?

Dan: "I would say, the sorting of items into bags/boxes. I wish we had a conveyor belt but that is too expensive."

Insight:

Dan is a highly motivated and dedicated volunteer, but he's often frustrated by the challenge of finding optimal volunteering opportunities. He wants to ensure his efforts are truly making the biggest difference possible.

Dan envisions a future where he can:

- **Pinpoint High-Need Opportunities:** He needs a volunteering network that clearly indicates the number of volunteers required for specific tasks. This would allow him to strategically spend his time where the need is greatest, ensuring his contributions are maximized.
- **Boost Efficiency with Best Practices:** To truly streamline his work and improve overall output, Dan would greatly benefit from a curated set of tutorial videos. These resources would demonstrate proven, common volunteering practices, such as the fundamentals of efficient item sorting and how to effectively collaborate in an assembly line for increased productivity.

By addressing these core needs, Dan believes he can transform his volunteering experience from simply showing up to truly optimizing his impact, helping more people in less time.

Stanley Gerzim

Name: Isaiah Abraham

Volunteers at: North Texas Food Bank

Overview of what Isaiah told me:

Isaiah often volunteers at NTFB with his church group. He's worked on packaging non-perishable items for those that are affected by natural disasters such as hurricanes, tornados, etc...

What I asked:

What made you want to volunteer?

Events like these are done with the youth at my church so it's a great way for me to connect with my friends and I feel like the free time I have is worth spending it for those who are going through hard times.

Do you prefer volunteering alone or with friends?

Definitely with friends! I'm able to catch up with them while also getting work done. I have volunteered alone a few times and it was difficult to get my job done.

Would you use an application to search for volunteering opportunities?

I'd be open to having an app to use, but every time I volunteer I find that a phone call is much easier. However, if an app is more efficient, I would be open to using it for sure.

Insight:

Volunteering at places can be used as a great way to be involved in the community and grow connections. Some prefer to work with peers rather than doing it alone. Utilizing an application for this task could be seen as useful if it provides efficiency and ease of access for users.

Jaden Flores

Name: Marcos R.

Volunteers at: Church

Overview of what they told me:

Marcos volunteers through his church where they regularly organize service events like food drives and cleanups. He doesn't go out of his way to search for opportunities because they're already presented to him through his community. He enjoys volunteering with friends and said that the social aspect is a big part of what makes it fun. He wouldn't personally use an app because he doesn't need to, but he thinks it could help others who don't have access to organized groups like his.

What I asked:

- How do you usually find out about volunteering opportunities?
- Do you feel like opportunities are clear and easy to find?
- Would you use an app for finding local volunteer events? Why or why not?
- Do you prefer volunteering alone or with friends?

Insight:

Marcos's situation highlights a segment of users who don't have trouble accessing volunteering opportunities due to an existing community. However, his answers also imply that people without that structure might struggle to get involved. Also, the fact that he enjoys doing it with friends supports the idea that social elements in the app might drive engagement.

Joshua Gambrell

Name: VS (20, UTD Student)

Volunteers at: N/A

Overview of what they told me:

VS is a student who occasionally learns about volunteer events through college clubs or their workplace. They told me about their frustration with the lack of clarity in how organizations present their day to day impact on their cause. Without a knowing what their contribution would achieve, they are less inclined to participate. The problem usually isn't motivation, but instead the uncertainty around purpose and effectiveness.

What I asked:

- How do you usually hear about volunteer opportunities?
- What's the hardest part about finding a good volunteering event?

Insight:

- Volunteers want to see exactly how their actions make a difference.
- Organizations need better, clearer communication to attract potential volunteers.

- Users are more likely to sign up if given tangible impact examples.
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Hector Gonzalez

Name: Lucy Shepherd (21, UTD student – Marketing major)

Volunteers at: N/A (never has, but wants to)

Overview of what Lucy told me:

Lucy has never volunteered before, but she says she's always wanted to. She's passionate about causes like education and sustainability but feels like she has no idea where to start. She mentioned trying to Google opportunities in the past, but said most of the results seemed outdated or generic. She also admitted she's nervous about showing up to something new by herself. She said if there was an app that made it easy to find something that matches her interests and gave her a clear idea of what to expect, she'd finally do it.

What I asked:

- Have you ever volunteered before? If not, what stopped you?
- What would make it easier for you to get started?
- Would you use an app to find local volunteering opportunities?

Insight:

Lucy represents a big portion of potential users: people who want to get involved but don't know how. The biggest barriers for her were lack of direction, uncertainty, and fear of doing it alone. A tool that gives people like her a filtered, step-by-step path into volunteering could make a real difference.

Preliminary User Needs

Based on the interviews we've collected, here are key needs and pain points that students and young adults face when it comes to volunteering:

1. Access and Discovery

- Some students don't know where to begin. Searching online feels overwhelming or outdated.
- Others, like those in churches or youth groups, already have easy access — but still rely on manual methods (like phone calls).

2. Ease of Getting Started

- First-timers feel intimidated or unsure about what volunteering actually involves.
- A smoother onboarding experience (like sign-up steps or expectations) would help remove friction.

3. Meaningful Contribution

- Volunteers want to know that their time matters — they want to feel useful and impactful.

- Showing task urgency or need level (like “3 volunteers still needed”) would help them choose how to help.
 - 4. **Social Connection**
 - Volunteering is more fun and productive when done with friends.
 - Users want to volunteer together or see who else is going — not go in blind.
 - 5. **Efficiency and Guidance**
 - Returning volunteers wish they had better tools to do the job more effectively.
 - Simple tutorial videos or “best practices” would be valuable for repeat events (e.g. food bank packing, sorting).
 - 6. **App Value Beyond Word of Mouth**
 - Those already tied to organized groups still rely on word of mouth or calls to get info.
 - An app needs to offer speed, organization, and flexibility to be worth switching over to.
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Team Contributions

- Jonathan Gonzalez: Interviewed Daniel Regio (Food Bank)
- Stanley Gerzim: Interviewed Isaiah Abraham (North Texas Food Bank)
- Jaden Flores: Interviewed Marcos R. (Church volunteering)
- Hector Gonzalez: Interviewed Lucy Shepherd (aspiring first-time volunteer)
- Joshua Gambrell: Interviewed VS (UTD student; interested but hesitant due to lack of impact clarity)